

■ BlankNullSequence

`---` (three `_` characters) or `BlankNullSequence[ ]` is a pattern object that can stand for any sequence of zero or more *Mathematica* expressions.

`---h` or `BlankNullSequence[h]` can stand for any sequence of expressions, all of which have head *h*.

Blank sequences work slightly differently depending on whether or not the head of the expression in which they appear is a symbol with the attribute `Flat`. ■ Consider matching the pattern $f[a_1, a_2, \dots, \text{---}, c_1, \dots]$ against the expression $f[a_1, a_2, \dots, b_1, \dots, c_1, \dots]$. If *f* is a symbol with attribute `Flat`, then the `---` will be taken to stand for the expression $f[b_1, \dots]$. If *f* is not a symbol with attribute `Flat`, then `---` will be taken to stand for the sequence of expressions $b_1, \dots$. With a named pattern, such as $x\text{---}$, *x* can be used only as an element in an expression. The sequence of expressions $b_1, \dots$ is “spliced in” to replace *x*, thereby usually increasing the length of the expression. ■ See page 557. ■ See also: `Pattern`.